

PRICKLY HEAT JD(U) chief Nitish Kumar and RJD's Tejashwi Yadav

ing trouble proved. On May 18, under a blistering sun in Nalanda, PK found himself stopped on way to Kalyanbigha, CM Nitish Kumar's ancestral village. "*Yahaan koi British Raj hai jo gaon mein jaane ke liye aapka permission chaahiye?*" he was heard fulminating, at a stone-faced SDM and a phalanx of officials. PK's caravan was out to test Nitish's three pledges on his own home turf. Had Rs 2 lakh been really given to each of the 9.4 million low-income families identified in Bihar's caste survey? Had Mahadalits been allotted land? Have land records been digitised and freed from corrupt local babus?

In the event, those remained a mystery. PK turned back, and instead held a rally at Biharsharief on May 20 where he formally launched his Yatra 2.0. As his caravan rolls into each village gathering, it unfolds with the same refrain: "You vote by caste or for 5 kg of grain. When was the last time you considered your children's future? Lalu Yadav is plotting his son's rise; what of yours? For once, look beyond the immediate." Bihar's villagers, long habituated to transactional voting, listen in rapt silence. Something resonates.

His vocabulary brims over with the promise of a post-caste politics, but as PK revs up for the hustings, the chess moves he's making show he's not without a keen eye towards the electoral potential of caste. On May 18, he secured the merger of Ramchandra Prasad 'RCP' Singh's Aap Sabki Awaaz Party into JSP. Who's RCP? An ex-bureaucrat and Nitish favourite, once his principal secretary, who leapt to great heights: JD(U) president, Rajya Sabha MP, and towards the end of that 2010-22 phase, even Union steel minister. More crucially, he's a Kurmi from Nalanda, like Nitish."RCP's entry will fortify our appeal among a key demographic," admits a JSP insider.

NUMERICAL NUANCES

Simultaneously, Kishor anointed Uday Singh. Resume: younger brother of the estimable ex-bureaucrat N.K. Singh, resourceful man from a prominent family who was twice BJP MP from Purnea and, after a bitter falling out and detour in the Congress, turned a benevolent patron for JSP in its salad days. Also, a Rajput face—so saffron territory. Counting Manoj Bharti, the Dalit state chief with an IIT/IFS bio, that's three caste boxes ticked. With top-tier lieutenants in place, Kishor can devote himself to the trail, promising governance over identity politics.

Takeaways

- **Prashant Kishor is revving up for polls, with a new yatra and a new set of lieutenants**
- **RCP Singh, former Nitish favourite, merges party with JSP; Uday Singh is president**

Numerical nuances frame his strategy as he goes tilting at the nearly four-decade-long RJD-JD(U) duopoly, with the BJP playing the long game. As many as 40 of Bihar's 243 assembly seats had victory margins lower than 3,500 votes in 2020. In November 2024, JSP contested four bypolls and finished third in two seats. In Imamganj, its 37,103 votes ensured the RJD's defeat. Overall, JSP got approximately 10 per cent of the votes. So the sight of PK wading through rice paddies and dusty lanes, talking his new talk in cramped huts and at bustling chaupals, can't be too soothing for the entrenched powers. ■



A STITCH IN TIME Mamata Banerjee with Abhishek

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**

A LIST OF DISTRICT presidents and suchlike may seem like a fairly ho-hum HR matter for the Trinamool Congress (TMC), a party that has 'grassroots' right there in its name. But this new roster was expected soon after the 2024 Lok Sabha election. The one year of no-show was marked by visible strain between West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee and nephew Abhishek Banerjee. A "balanced" reset is what they're calling it—a truce between Mamata's old guard and Abhishek's 'reformist' bloc.

It arrives at a politically delicate juncture. The 2026 assembly polls loom ever closer, and a long-pending organisational reshuffle would seem basic to prepping up for combat. That aspect of urgency has acquired a keener edge than one would have presumed for a party that